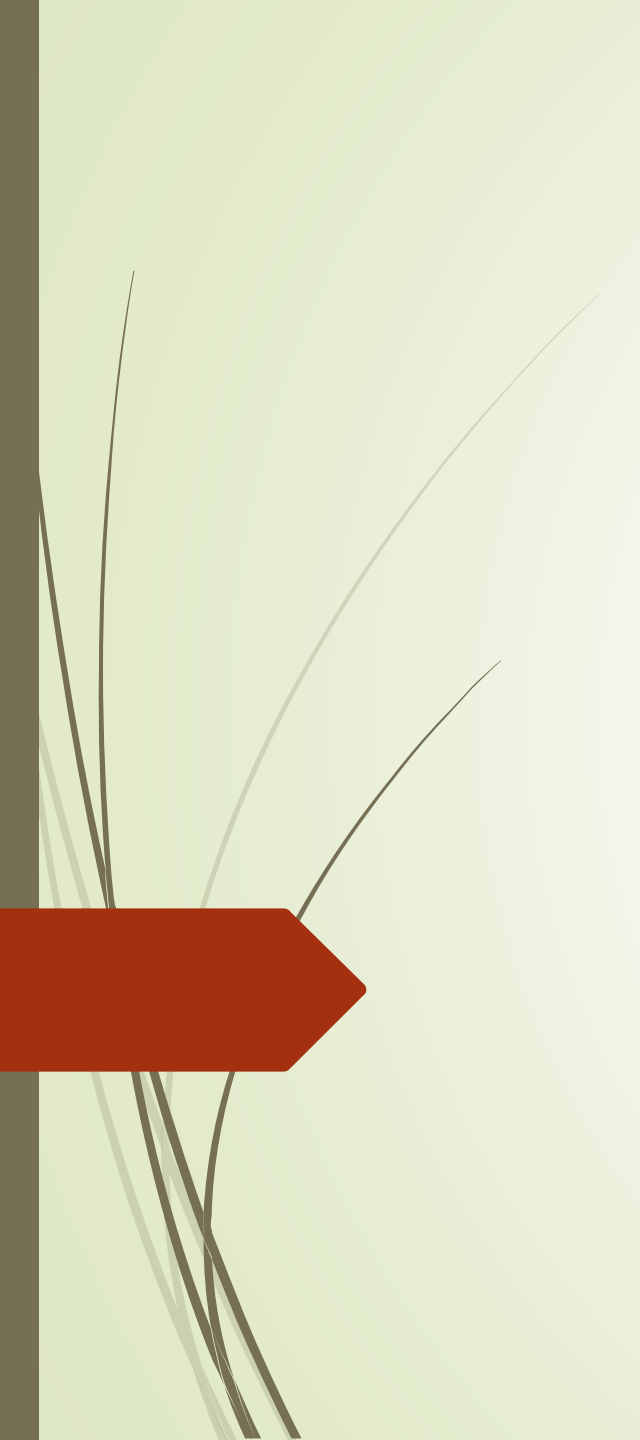




Important Directions

- **Read through all slides**
- **Watch all videos**



Social and Emotional Development in Middle Childhood



Humans beings are searching for social connections

- So far, we have looked at the **first** social context we grow up in - the **parent-child relationship**.
- The next very important social context we inhabit is the **peer group**.

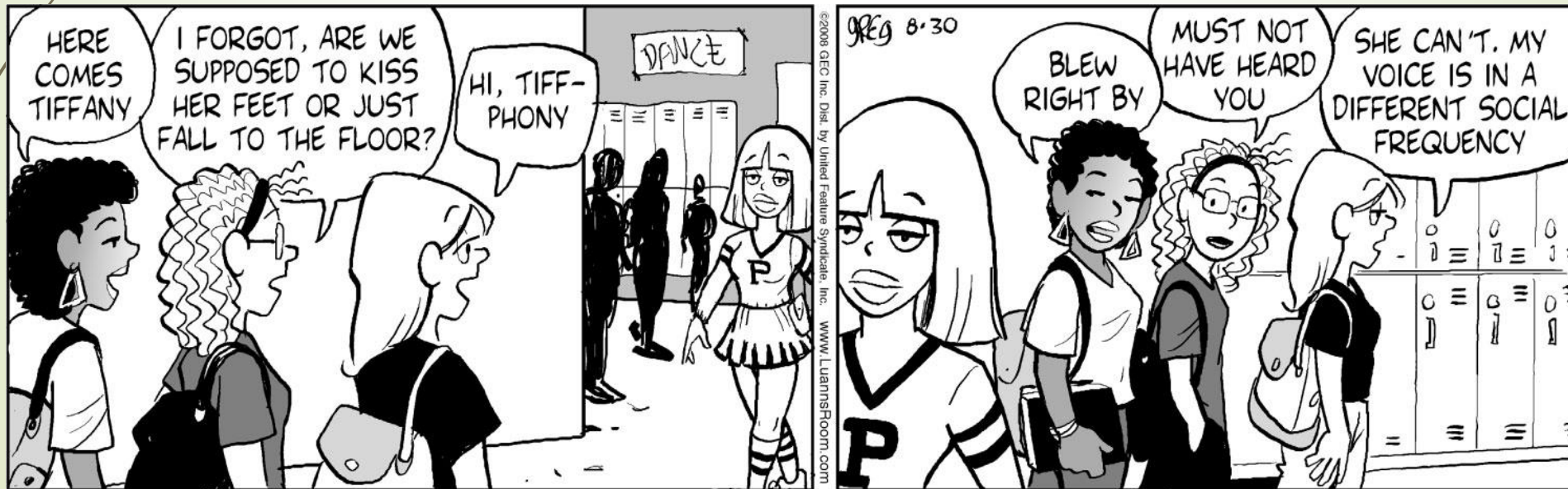
Social Status - What does it mean?

Ranking

Level

Position

Standing



Peer Acceptance and Rejection

- Sociometric techniques: Assessing who is liked and who is disliked in a group.
- Children are asked “Who do you like to hang out/sit next to”
- “Who do you least like to hang out/sit next to”

Accepted/Popular

Rejected

Controversial

Neglected



Why are some children Unpopular?

- Rejected or unpopular children lack the **social skills** that their better liked peers possess.
- We are sensitive to social cues- “Weird”, “Socially awkward” are almost used synonymously.
- Rejected children socially different: They exhibit aggression OR are shy and withdrawn.

A young child with light brown hair, wearing a red hooded sweatshirt and blue jeans, stands in front of a weathered wooden fence. The child has a somber expression. The background is slightly out of focus, showing more of the fence and some greenery. The overall tone is somewhat melancholic.

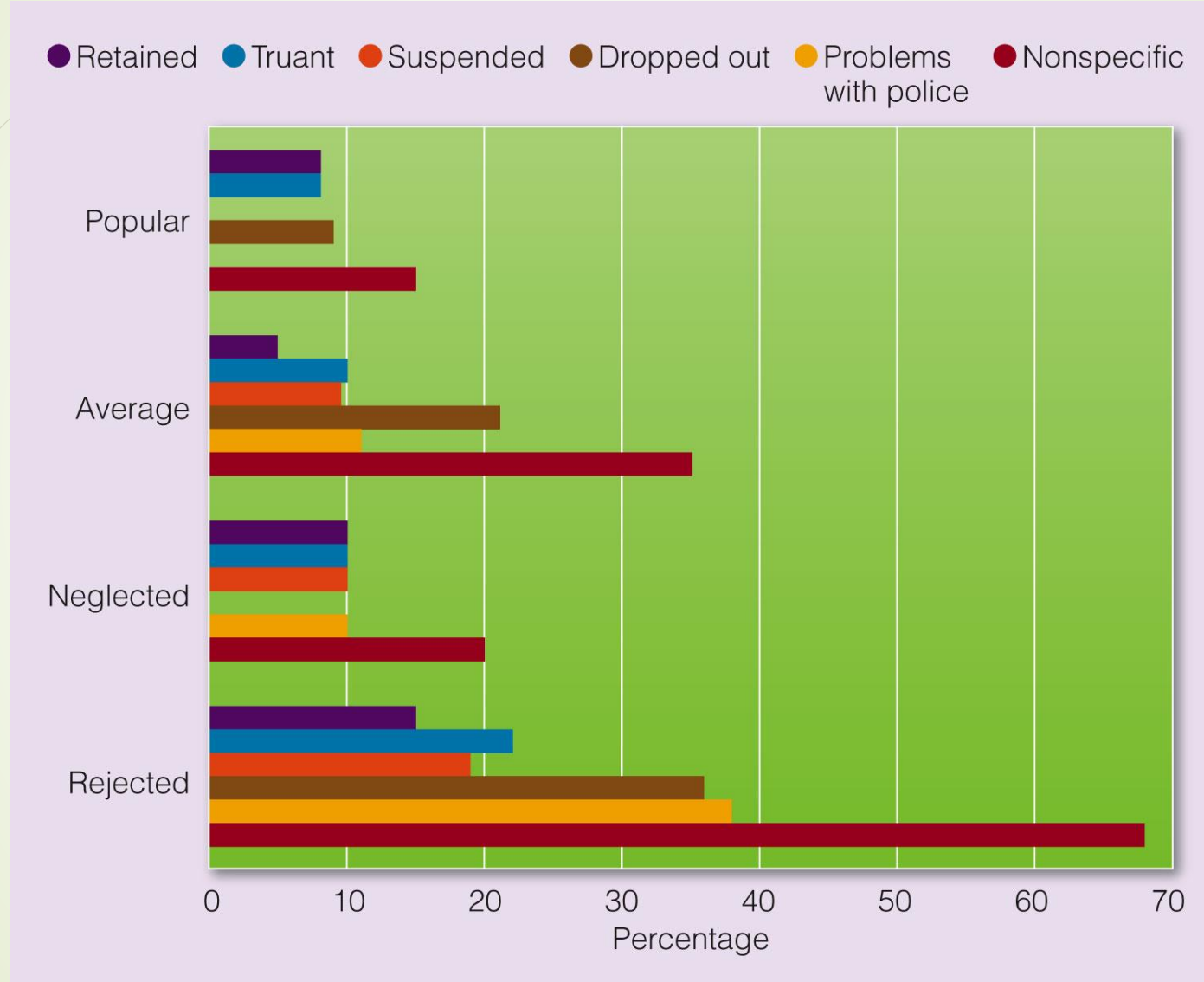
Does early peer rejection matter?

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=X7EFYwUopf8>

Children who are classified as Rejected in 5th Grade, have greater behavior problems in High school. In comparison to average children, they are more likely to:

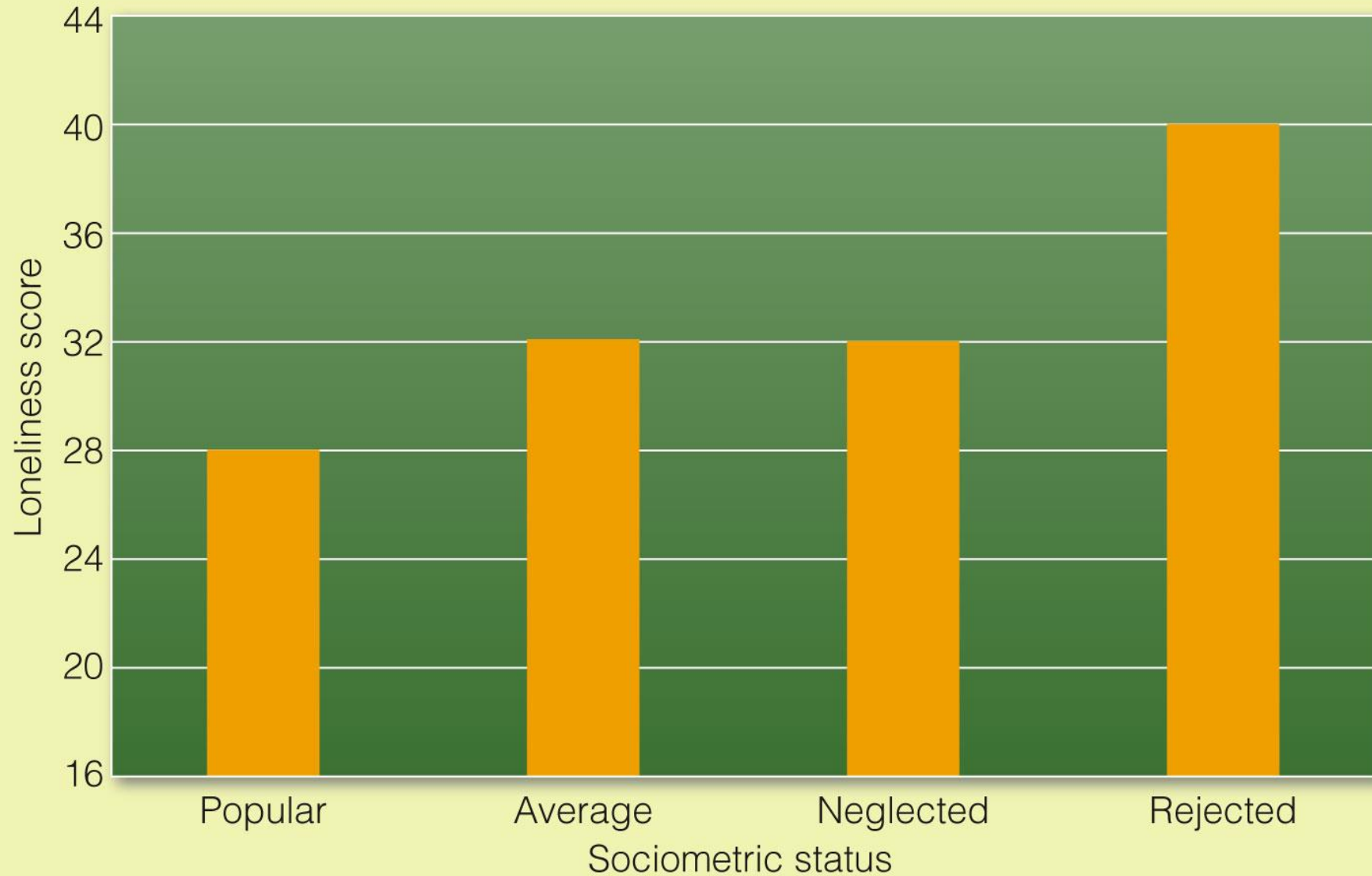
- Drop out of school
- Get in trouble with the police
- Display more externalizing behaviors

The relationship between children's sociometric status in fifth grade and academic and behavior problems through high school.



Kupersmidt & Coie, 1990

Loneliness scores for popular, average, neglected, and rejected third-through sixth-grade children.



Asher, Hymel, & Renshaw, 1984

A young child with brown hair, wearing a red hooded sweatshirt and blue jeans, stands against a weathered wooden wall. The child has a sad or pouting expression. The background is a light-colored wooden wall with vertical planks. The overall image has a slightly faded, artistic feel.

Why is rejection so painful?

- An assessment of effects of social ostracism: The Cyberball experiment
- Social rejection pain= Physical pain
- Anterior cingulate cortex

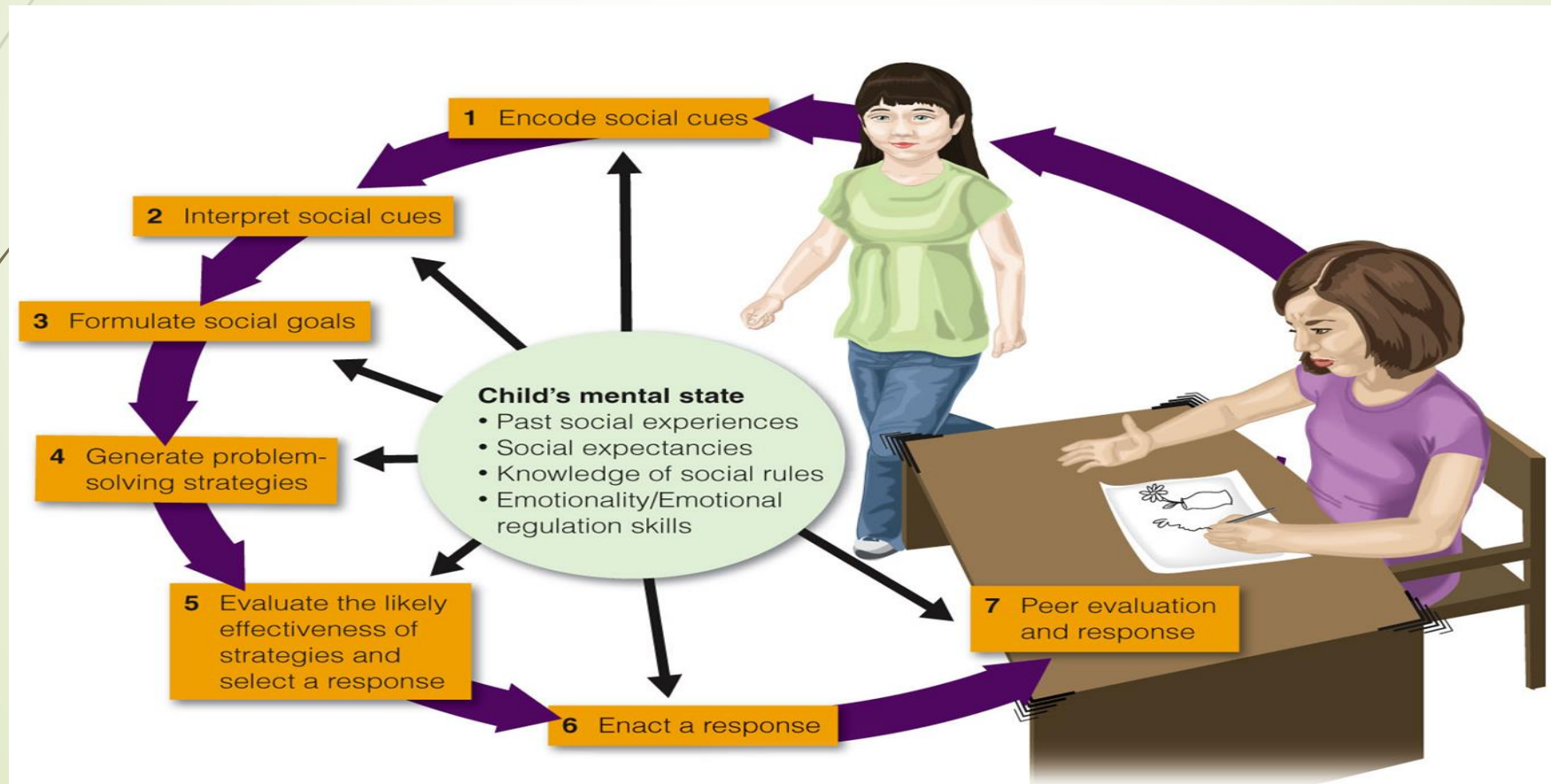
Outcomes associated with social pain over prolonged periods

- **Social pain linked to aggression and violence- even towards innocent bystanders.**
- **The Shame response to rejection: Correlations between social pain, subsequent physical pain, and violent behavior towards others**

Rejection and Aggression

Hostile Attribution Bias:

- Deficits in processing of social information plays central role in aggressive behavior of rejected adolescent



Rejection in Peer Groups

- Three types of unpopular adolescents
 - Aggressive
 - fights with other students, bullies others
 - Withdrawn
 - exceedingly shy, timid, and inhibited
 - victims of bullying
 - Aggressive-Withdrawn
 - hostile, but nervous about initiating friendships

Why is rejection so damning?

- ➡ Because human beings are basically searching for social connections.
- ➡ Social connections and relationships are the bread and butter of being human.
- ➡ Attachment with parents sets the stage.
- ➡ Throughout life, we seek social and emotional bonds with important others.
- ➡ Evolutionary theory posits that Social and Physical pain overlap to warn people about the importance of their social needs.

What can we do to promote greater acceptance?

- Early intervention and education- schools, teachers and parents must work together.
“You can’t say you can’t play”
- Teaching children social and emotional concepts has positive effects on academic achievement.
- Schools must adopt the philosophy of acceptance
- Even small acts of acceptance reduce aggression and increase feelings of belongingness.



Interventions at later points in development

“We dine together”

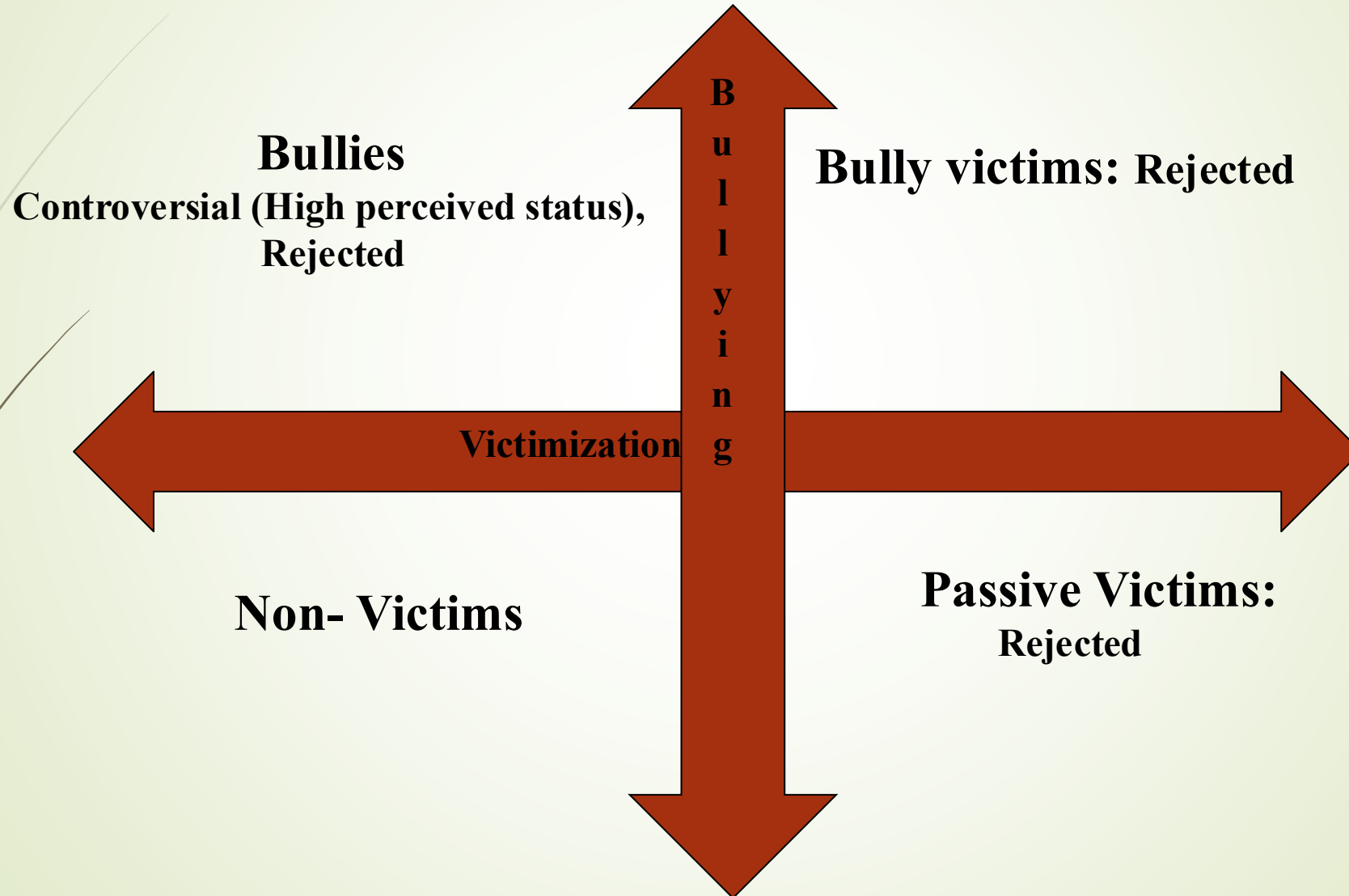
<https://youtu.be/QdDa2outstI?t=10>



Characteristics of popular youth

- Possess peer valued objects or characteristics
- Physically attractive
- Do well in school, Leadership, Athletic etc
- Socially competent
 - ✓ Initiate positive interactions
 - ✓ Respond positively to peers
 - ✓ Resolve conflicts smoothly

Bullying and Victimization



- 
- A meta-analysis of 80 studies on **bullying involvement rates among** 12-18 year old students (for both bullying others and being bullied) found
 - 35% of students are involved in traditional bullying and 15% are involved in cyberbullying (Modecki et al., 2014)
 - Most common reasons - Looks (55%), Body shape (37%), and Race (16%) (Davis & Nixon, 2010)
 - <http://www.pacer.org/bullying/resources/stats.asp>

Victimization

- Victims of bullying may lack the social skills and social understanding necessary to be popular with peers
 - Easy targets for bullying
 - Creates a cycle of teasing, feeling less socially adept, leading to more bullying
 - Blame themselves for their victimization
 - Experience depression and loneliness (Rigby, 2004)
- Victimization can lead to academic problems and lower earnings as an adult because of the cyclical nature of bullying





Q. Do you think this issue is tackled well enough?

Q. What are some challenges to better solving this problem?

Some damaging myths

- Myth: Bullying affects the bully and the victim alone.
- **Truth:** Witnessing bullying is distressing for bystanders as well
- Myth: Bullying is common among children and they should learn to sort it out themselves. It makes one resilient.
- **Truth:** Bullying results in poor mental health outcomes.
- What does the bully's success depend on?- Bystanders watching the event
- Anti-bullying norms must be created and enforced without exception.
- Bystanders must be empowered and trained to intervene, and given support so they feel safe.
- Research shows that when a bystander intervenes, bullying stops within seconds
- Olweus Bullying Prevention Program-Holistic interventions

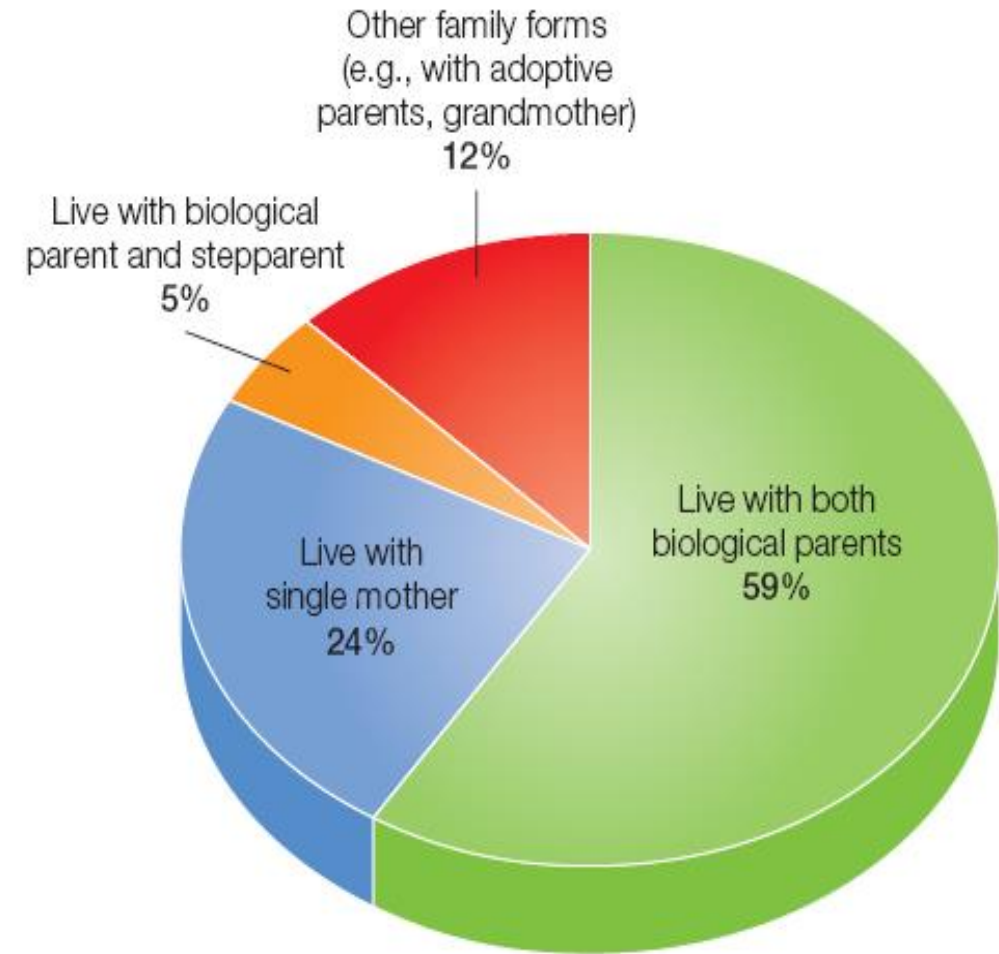
Family Relations



- Parenting moves from direct control toward co-regulation
- More freedom and more responsibility during this time period

Diverse Family Forms

- Wide variability in family forms: Single-parent, divorced, step-families becoming more common.
- Children from straight and homosexual families highly similar (Goldberg, 2010; Patterson, 2002).
- Quality of parenting/parent-child relations, and relationships between parents/relationship climate better predictor of child outcomes than sexual orientation/sex of parent.
- Single mother families-Importance of resources
- When mother makes enough money, children of single-parent families function just as well as children in two-parent families.



Family patterns in the United States through Middle Childhood

Outcomes of Divorce

- Numerous effects of divorce include
 - Externalizing behaviors – impulsive and conflicts with family
 - Internalizing problems – depression, anxiety, phobias, and sleep disturbances
- Emotion coaching mitigates some of these ill-effects of divorce
- Minimal parental conflict during/after divorce also protects children against these ill-effects.